



Loosened in Translation

Clause-level divergence across six community-language versions of one council’s hall-hire conditions

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The problem

A council publishes the conditions of hire for its community halls in six community languages, and counts the six as its access measure. Whether the six say the same thing has never been read back. Does a rule survive the round trip?

Research questions

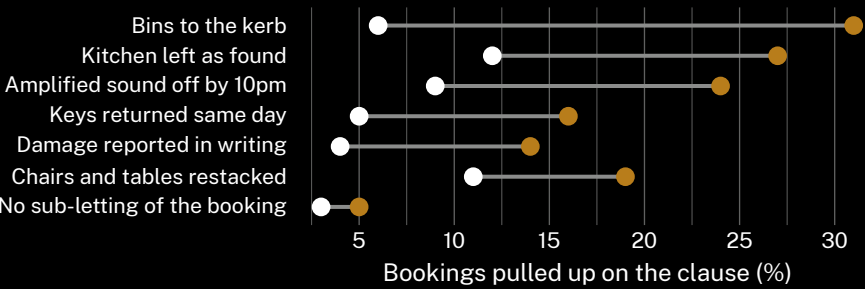
- Do the six published versions carry the source clause set at equivalent obligation strength?
- Where clauses diverge, does the divergence loosen the obligation or tighten it?
- Do hirers issued a diverged version feel any less certain about what they agreed to?

Study design

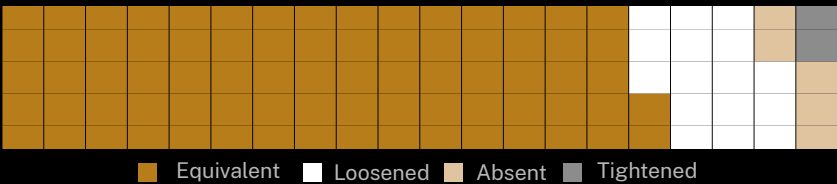
- 31-clause source text · six published versions · two blind back-translators each · 18 months
- Clause-level alignment; each of 186 clause-instances coded equivalent, loosened, tightened or absent (inter-coder agreement 0.84)
- 1,140 bookings linked to caretaker handback notes; hirer certainty surveyed at key return (n = 612); coding frame fixed before linkage

What we found

43 of 186 clause-instances (23%) diverge from the source: loosening accounts for 30, outright absence for nine. Divergence tracks later enforcement — bookings issued a version in which a clause had loosened or vanished are pulled up on that clause roughly three times as often. Hirer certainty does not move with it (r = 0.04, ns); respondents on the diverged versions were as sure of the conditions as anyone else.



Bookings pulled up on each clause, by the version the hirer was issued — each pair sets the source text against the six community-language versions pooled (gold), across 1,140 bookings and 18 months. The kerbside-bin clause, absent from four of the six versions, carries the widest gap at 25 points; the sub-letting clause, equivalent in all six, is flat.



Alignment code assigned to each of the 186 clause-instances (31 source clauses across six published versions), one cell per percentage point. Divergence is overwhelmingly one-directional: 30 loosened and nine absent against four tightened.

Implications

Coverage is counted in languages published; equivalence is counted nowhere. The currency attestation renewed each year is signed against the number six, which the audit suggests is not the quantity in question.

Loosening is not random across the clause set. It concentrates in the clauses a hirer meets last — what to do with the bins, the keys, and the hall at the end of the night — and those are the clauses a handback note records.

At the hall the pattern reads as a difference in how carefully hirers follow the rules. It is more parsimoniously a difference in which rules they were handed.

Next: a clause-equivalence schedule tabled for the 2027 conditions review, which has in the interim commissioned a seventh version.

Selected references

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De-identified booking records only; no hirer contact details retained. Back-translators worked blind to the source text and to each other. Coding frame pre-registered; no clause was recoded after linkage.

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